With different calamities, stained red and beaten

In every home, they remembered the true justice of the Amir
Night and day they longed for the Amir[23]

Most British officials now recognised that the Anglo-Sadozai regime was failing – certainly few took so dismissive and over-confident an attitude as Macnaghten – but they differed from each other as to the solution needed to turn the situation around. In London, John Cam Hobhouse, the President of the Board of Control, who in his youth had been Lord Byron's close friend and travelling companion, argued that what was really needed was radically to increase troop numbers. Either Afghanistan should be relinquished completely, or it should be held in strength. He argued that the number of troops on the ground should be enormously increased from the skeletal garrison to which they had been reduced after the surrender of Dost Mohammad Khan. Expenditure and investment in the country should rise, he wrote, and there should be greater control over the Afghan government. The basic fact that 'the British are masters of the country' should be recognised, and Shuja should be made to obey all the orders given to him. Retreat should be out of the question.[24]

Burnes was also keen on marginalising Shuja and reforming his corrupt government. In August 1840, just before the surrender of Dost Mohammad, he had written Macnaghten a long memo expressing his view that the Shah's government was inefficient, unpopular and expensive, and that greater British interference in the administration was the only way to save the regime. He was not personally in favour of full annexation, and he was clear 'that we shall never settle Afghanistan at the point of a bayonet', but he noted that many of his colleagues were now coming to believe the best solution was to annex both the Punjab and Afghanistan into the Company Raj.[25]

In his private correspondence Burnes was more scathing, and pointed the finger of blame at Auckland and Macnaghten. 'There is nothing here but downright imbecility,' he wrote to his brother-in-law Holland.[26] 'We are in possession of the cities,' he told his elder brother around the same time, 'but have not got the country or the [support of the] people, and have as yet done nothing liberally to consolidate Afghanistan. Lord A has it in his power to take Peshawar and Herat now and restore the Monarchy, enable it to pay itself and relieve India from all expenses, but he will do nothing. *Après moi*